

Kajitsu



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先付け
Sakizuke

吸い物
Suimono

御飯
Gohan

向付
Mukōzuke

口取り
Kuchidori

煮物お椀
Nimonowan

焼き物
Yakimono

揚げ物
Agemono

お凌ぎ
Oshinogi

焚き合わせ
Takiawase

八寸
Hassun

食事
Shokuji

水物
Mizumono

甘味
Kanmi

お抹茶
Omatcha

Hōba Miso-Yaki Ichō to Nama-Fu
朴葉味噌焼き 銀杏と生麩
Hōba style grilled food: ginkgo and seitan

Akadashi Shitate Hakusai to Toki-Karashi
赤出汁仕立 白菜と溶き辛子
Special tailored red miso soup: Chinese napa cabbage and melted Japanese mustard

Kuri Gohan
栗ご飯
Rice with chestnut

Hōrensō to Age no Ohitashi
法蓮草と揚げのお浸し
Spinach and fried tofu soaked in kombucha

Yaki Kuro-Gomadōfu Monaka
焼き黒胡麻豆腐 最中
Grilled black sesame tofu monaka

Owan Haninattsusukusshu Suri Nagashi to Hasune Manjū to Yuzu
お椀 ハニーナッツスクアツシュすり流しと蓮根饅頭と柚子
Soup dish: grated honey nut squash with lotus root manjū and yuzu

Fukiyose Akitake Sugi Ituyaki Kicetsu no Moriawase Kuri Pēsuto Daikon Nama-fu to Miso
吹寄せ 秋茸杉板焼 季節の盛合せ：栗ペースト 大根 生麩と味噌
Fukiyose: charcoal-grilled fall mushroom, fall assortment of chestnut paste, raw daikon radish, nama-fu with miso

Matsutake Furai Sanshō Shōyu Jikasei Usutāsōsu
松茸フライ 山椒醤油 自家製ウスターソース
Fried matsutake, sanshō soy sauce, housemade Worcestershire sauce

Hashiri no Kabura Shun no Kaki Yuchoi Toryufu to Toryufu no Shiraae
はしりの蕪、旬の柿、ユチョイ、トリユフとトリユフの白和え
First turnips of the season, seasonal persimmon, yuchoi, truffle, and truffle-tofu cream

Aki take to aki yasai no nabe shitate
秋茸と秋野菜の鍋仕立て
Hotpot of fall mushrooms and vegetables

Chishatō Miso-zuke Tazunazushi Marujō Remon Ni
チシャトウ味噌漬手綱寿司、丸十レモン煮
Miso-marinated celtuce sushi and lemon flavored sweet potato

Take Sciro Soba
茸せいろ蕎麦
Soba in bamboo steamer with mushroom

Kicetsu no Kudamono Ringo no Kantenyose
季節の果物：りんごの寒天寄
Seasonal fruit: Apple and apple-flavored kanten jelly cake

Kicetsu no Wagashi “Iga-guri” Monburan Kēki
季節の和菓子：「毬栗」モンブランケーキ
Seasonal wagashi: “chestnut with burrs” chestnut mont-blanc

Kyōto no Ippodō-saho no matcha
京都の一保堂茶舗の抹茶
Matcha by Ippodo Tea Company from Kyoto

雪待月のお献立

Kajitsu





Kajitsu has long been on my waitlist as it is the only restaurant in New York City that offers Shōjin Ryōri, the precursor of kaiseki cuisine as well as a crucial devotion cuisine for monks. This time I finally booked Kajitsu to taste their November menu. Located only three blocks east of Bryant Park, Kajitsu unveils a cozy atmosphere upon arrival. Kajitsu is on the second floor and has more of a zen ambiance compared to its sister restaurant Kokage on the first floor. Each month, Kajitsu will update its menu to feature the ingredients at their best in the current season. Before the dinner, the chef showcases the main ingredients of the season that will be featured on the current menu. For November, the menu focuses on squash, chestnut, and mushroom.

The first plate is the seasonal starter called “Sakizuke” in cha-kaiseki traditional. For November, Kajitsu is featuring Hōba miso-yaki nama-fu and ginkgo nuts. Hōba miso-yaki is a regional food from Gifu 岐阜 and Nagano 長野 Prefectures of Japan. It refers to the method of preparing miso by frying it on a dried Japanese Magnolia leaf. In this dish, both the ginkgo nuts and the nama-fu have a soft texture and light flavor, which are unfortunately overshadowed by the heaviness of the miso paste. The miso paste per se imparts an alluring leafy aroma, but the brininess is occupying too much attention. The brininess amplifies the light bitterness in ginkgo nuts, turning the refreshing taste to an unpleasant bitterness-dominated heavy amalgam.





In the cha-kaiseki tradition, rice, soup, and a small side dish are served to offer gratitude to the customer that made the long trek to the restaurant and to alleviate their empty stomachs before the matcha tea ceremony. Here we have a special tailored red miso soup with Chinese napa cabbage and melted Japanese mustard, a rice dish simply finished with sesame and chestnut, and a cold spinach dish with fried tofu soaked in kombucha. Both the spinach and the rice have a light flavor profile, but the miso soup showcases extravagant richness, which tastes offensive among the trio. The rice dish is the opposite as it is way too under-seasoned. The chestnut per se doesn't deliver much flavor. The spinach as a palate-cleanser dish is the best offer from the trio. Light yet imparts dimensions of umami.



While the former courses are seasonal and would update each month accordingly, the next course is the pièce de résistance of Kajitsu and will appear on the menu every month. Here we have the signature dish featuring housemade black sesame tofu seasoned with wasabi served in a monaka, a crispy rice wafer. The black sesame tofu is called Gomadōfu in Japanese, yet it has nothing to do with tofu besides their similar texture. Sesame tofu has a much creamier texture than tofu. After being grilled and seasoned with wasabi, it exhibits a unique texture and flavor profile on the palate reminiscent of ankimo. The creaminess goes along perfectly with the airy crispiness of the monaka.

Next up is the seasonal soup dish, a grated honey nut squash with lotus root manjū and yuzu. This is the second soup dish on the menu, yet it showcases a completely different texture and flavor profile. The honey nut squash soup has a satin-like tactile and a translucent texture. It imparts a natural sweetness that feels refreshing and satisfying on the palate. As for the Manjū, it is a variety of traditional Japanese confection. Here the lotus manjū tastes more like a daifuku than the traditional manjū. The texture of this lotus manjū is perfectly counterpointed by the squash soup. The appearance of yuzu is subtle yet brings the mélange an additional freshness.





Next up is a relatively complex course featuring yakimono that emanates the autumn atmosphere of fukiyose (吹き寄せ). Fukiyose literally means “blowing” and “collect” it can refer to a medley of diverse objects. In Japanese cuisine, it may refer to a dish with simmered and fried foods such as vegetables and root vegetables. Here we have a luxury trifold collection. On the first serve, we have a duo of mushrooms wrapped in woods and grilled on charcoal. Unfortunately, the aromas of the wood and the charcoal are delivered enough into the mushroom. The second serve is a small portion of chestnut paste. The final serve is an assortment of raw radish, nama-fu with miso, and myoga. The spiciness of the raw radish seems to be abrupt in this combination.



After the complex combination, Kajitsu presents me with a simple dish of fried matsutake with sanshō and sanshō infused soy sauce. I never understand the benefit of frying matsutake or kani. For me, frying may be used for beef or chicken. Tempura would be much better for matsutake. Nonetheless, the overall palate is flavorful especially when enjoyed with the housemade Worcestershire sauce, which provides essential richness as well as a hint of acidity that not only amplifies the umami of matsutake but also counters the heaviness.

Next up is a marvelous Oshinogi dish featuring the first turnips of the season, persimmon, yuchoi, truffle, and truffle-tofu cream. Oshinogi refers to a light meal that is served in addition to the fixed mealtime, and has the meaning of surpassing hunger. This word was originally used in tea kaiseki cuisine with the same meaning as dim sum. Though the dish is light and refreshing, the subtle nuances are thought-provoking. The pristine flavor of turnip, the natural sweetness of persimmon, the pastoral taste of yuchoi, the richness and earthy aroma of truffle, the creaminess of the cream, all singing together in harmony.





Next up is a Takiawase dish, a simmered dish in which vegetables are simmered according to individual characteristics and served in a single bowl. It tends to be important to incorporate seasonal ingredients and to consider the color when serving. Here the leek is the most important counterpart of the centered ingredient — mushroom. After the Takiawase, I am served with a Hassun dish. In the *cha-kaiseki* tradition they originally provided seasonal fruits of the land alongside fruits of the sea. At Kajitsu they use seasonal vegetables to reconceptualize this tradition. This Hassun dish consists of a piece of Tazunazushi made with miso-marinated celtuce and a petit slice of lemon flavored sweet potato.





Finally, a Shokuji dish marks the end of the savory part of the meal. The shokuji course is usually a gohan dish or a noodle dish. Today I am served with refreshing soba noodle with yuzu zest, paired with a rather heavyweight mushroom dipping soup. The dipping soup is rich in umami yet imparts exorbitant brininess. For desserts, the first serve is a seasonal apple kanten jelly. The juiciness of the freshly sliced apple goes perfectly well with the resilience of kanten jelly. The next one is a piece of wagashi called “Iga-guri,” which means “chestnut with burrs,” a frequent sight on the paths of autumnal walks. Chestnuts are one of several symbols, along with persimmons, mushrooms, sweet potatoes, and ears of rice, for “Minori-no-aki” (Harvest Season) in Japan.

